Q+A

KEEPING IT REAL

At 87, **Shyam Benegal** still has many stories to tell. As he prepares for the release of his latest film, *Mujib: The Making of a Nation*, a Sheikh Mujibur Rahman biopic, the veteran filmmaker talks about his thirst for knowledge and what keeps him going.

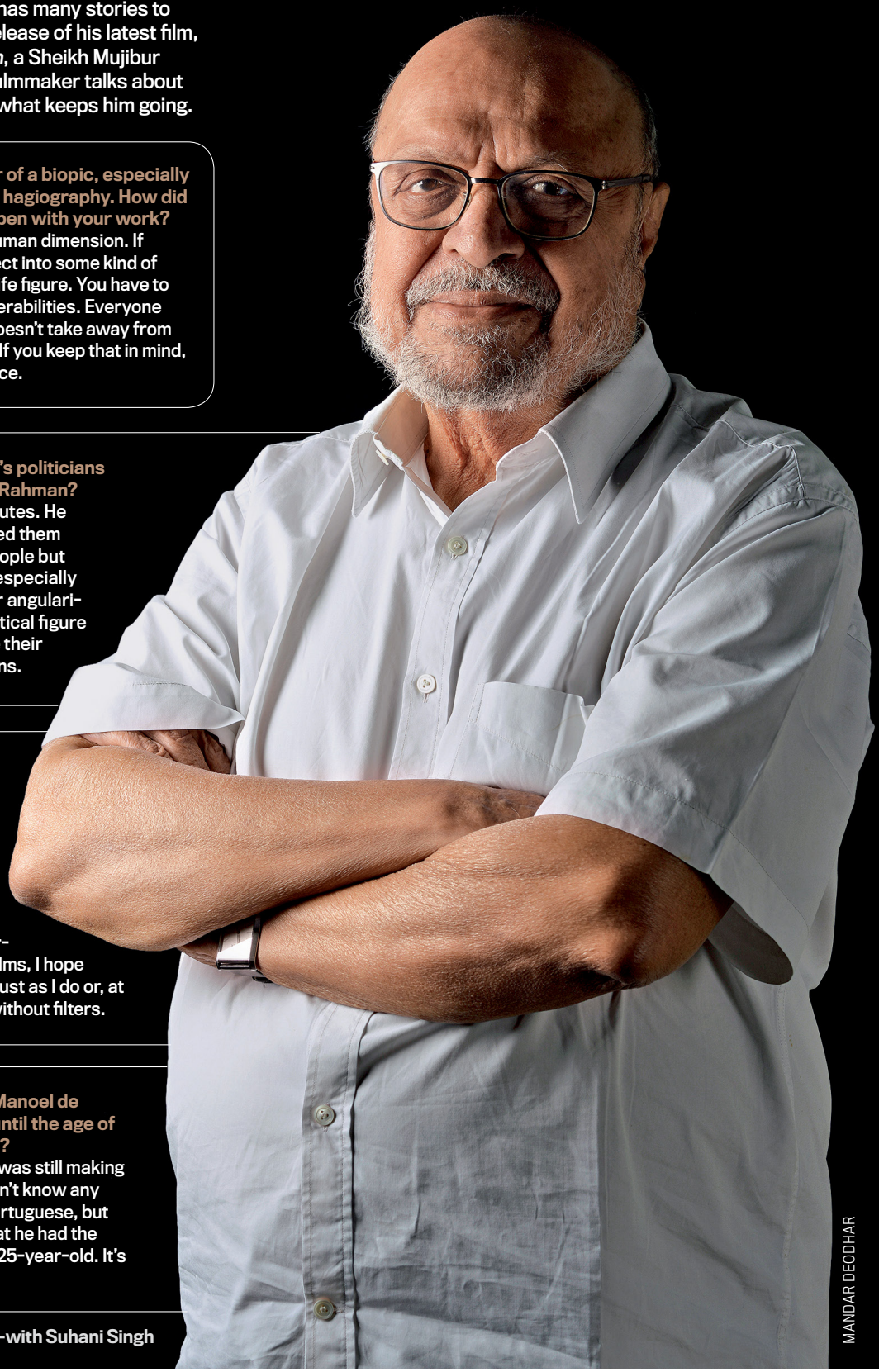
Q. There's always a danger of a biopic, especially a political one, becoming a hagiography. How did you ensure that didn't happen with your work?
You should never lose the human dimension. If you do, you make your subject into some kind of a superman, a larger-than-life figure. You have to see a person with their vulnerabilities. Everyone has an Achilles heel, but it doesn't take away from their capability or strength. If you keep that in mind, everything else falls into place.

Q. What lessons can today's politicians learn from Sheikh Mujibur Rahman?
I'll start with his good attributes. He loved his people, but he loved them too much. He trusted his people but he trusted them too much, especially his aides. He didn't see their angularities. It's important for a political figure to know that they, too, have their weaknesses and temptations.

Q. Apart from hard-hitting social dramas, political history is your forte. What draws you to these subjects?
One of my primary interests is finding out everything I possibly can about my country. One is forever learning. Through my films, I hope audiences learn something just as I do or, at least, learn to look at India without filters.

Q. Portuguese filmmaker Manoel de Oliveira directed films up until the age of 105. What keeps you going?
I met him in Lisbon when he was still making films at the age of 96. He didn't know any English, I didn't know any Portuguese, but what was important was that he had the energy and excitement of a 25-year-old. It's what I rely on too.

–with Suhani Singh



MANDAR DEODHAR